Trauma Survivor

Introductory Notes

If your client is suffering from flashbacks, ask them to rate the severity on a scale of 1 to 10, where 1 doesn't adversely affect them and 10 severely upsets them. During the information-gathering part of your session, see if you can identify any of the client's negative self-beliefs from the language they use and how they would have preferred to feel or react. You should also set up a 'safe place' to take your client to in the event of the memories being too much to cope with at this stage.

Begin with your favorite **Induction** and **Deepener** from Hypnotic World. NOTE

You are listening to me now because you have been through an experience that no one should ever have to go through, and as a result of that experience, you have suffered some undesirable after-effects.

You are aware that nothing anyone can say can change whatever it was that happened and it might seem as though no one can understand what you have endured which, in a way, is perfectly correct as we all respond to situations in our own unique way.

However, what I can do, with your co-operation, of course, is to help you to come to terms with what happened and realise that you are a survivor, rather than a victim.

And even though it is difficult to believe at the moment, you ***do*** have a future, and a very bright one at that.

You possibly feel that you have hit rock bottom and if so, perhaps you can already see that you can now only go up.

But you have to do your part too. I'm not a magician, and unfortunately, I can't just wave a magic wand and make it all disappear.

So I would like to ask you to go along with the things that I say, even if you feel you are pretending, because if you pretend enough, your imagination will eventually take over and

pretending, because if you pretend enough, your imagination will eventually take over and turn your imaginings into a new reality.

Your imagination is your most powerful asset and it is vital that you channel it in a positive direction; if you don't do this then negativity can take hold and try to lead you back to that downward path.

So, I want you to harness your imagination as you would with a horse. Pull the reins now and again, when necessary, especially when you need to change direction or shout 'whoa' when you want your beast to stop.

Horses are beautiful, faithful creatures, and they instinctively know their way back home.

They can lead you on wild adventures, or take you back to the safety you crave.

But before we embark on our journey, I would like to suggest some practical tips for coming to terms with what happened to you.

And as I'm sure you are aware, the most important thing you can do is to talk openly and honestly to people who care about you, and tell them how you are feeling.

After all, people may think you are coping well; they cannot see what is going on in your mind or your body, so if they think you are alright, they probably don't want to risk talking about the event in case it reminds you.

Trauma survivors can experience a whole range of emotions; these could include fear or anger, lack of confidence or a feeling that nothing in life is worth it anymore.

So, if you haven't already done so, and if it is appropriate, I would like to suggest that you join a support group of some sort where you can air your feelings with others who have had a similar experience.

And if there is no support group in your area, perhaps you could consider starting one in order to help others who have lived through what you did.

Just getting together once a week or fortnight can help you feel better and less alone in what happened.

The next thing I'd recommend is making exercise a regular part of your life. This could be any sort of exercise you enjoy. It might be kick-boxing, wrestling, running or weight lifting.

Or it could be cycling, swimming, rugby or tennis. It really doesn't matter what form of exercise you use as long as you enjoy it.

This will help to release the endorphins, those feel-good chemicals in your brain, and lift your mood.

So we have dealt with the practicalities, and now, let us begin.

We have several tools in our workbox that can help; it is important to find one that suits you, so I will describe a few different ones.

NOTE

If your client isn't experiencing any of the following symptoms then don't mention them as they might feel as though they **should** be experiencing them. Just mention any that are relevant and tailor the script to their needs.

These are techniques you can use as and when you need them. For example, if you experience panic or flashbacks, outbursts of anger or episodes of sadness.

Pent-up feelings or anger:

I know you have been experiencing episodes of sadness or anger, so I want you to go inside and locate those feelings.

Where do you feel them? Are they in your abdomen, your heart, your head or somewhere else in your body?

PAUSE

Wait for a response.

Get in touch with those feelings now. Give them a name and a color. What color would you say that anger or sadness is?

Wait for a response. PAUSE

Give those feelings a shape; they could be hard and prickly, or maybe they feel like a heavy brick in that area of your body (*state the area*).

It could be that those feelings are slimy like jelly, or like rubber or putty or something else, or perhaps they feel jagged or sharp?

Use your imagination to form your own, personal impression of those feelings; feel the weight and the shape; perhaps they even have a sound? If so, notice it now as I am quiet for a moment or two.

Short pause. PAUSE

That's good; and now that you have located those feelings I wonder if you can imagine, if there is more than one, that they are fusing together into one single mass.

And as you notice that feeling and its position in your body, I want you to find you can move it.

Perhaps it moves easily and smoothly or it might need a bit of a push.

But I want you to move that mass to another area of your body. Feel it moving to your right shoulder at the top of your arm and then slowly working down through the arm.

That feeling is moving down your right arm, past your wrist and into your hand.

Hold it there in the palm of your hand and when you can feel it there, when you can feel that weight and shape and color and perhaps even its temperature and the way that it

sounds, bend your fingers and thumb around the object and hold it there in your right hand.

This object in your right hand represents the unwelcome feelings that you have been experiencing since that trauma occurred.

And now it is time to be rid of those feelings so in a moment I'm going to ask you to release them by opening your right hand and blowing or throwing them away, sending them where they deserve to be.

When you are ready to be free of those negative feelings, just allow your fingers to relax and release them; that's right, just relax and release them when I say the word now.

Now. *(Spoken forcefully).*

Get rid of those unwanted feelings. You didn't invite them and they have no right to be in your body. Blow them away or throw them away; eliminate them once and for all.

Let go, right now.

And as you blow or throw those feelings away, notice how your body begins to feel lighter and freer, as though a weight has been lifted off you.

And a weight ***has*** lifted off you. It is ***gone***, and you are ***free*** to get on with the business of living in the ***now***.

As those negative feelings disappear, imagine you are surrounded by an aura of positive, golden energy that consists of calm and peaceful feelings; feelings of peace and tranquillity as you realise that the past is past.

You cannot change it; you can only accept that it happened and make a decision to move on; to continue living a life that is free and worth living; a life full of courage and compassion, and accumulated wisdom.

Flashbacks using an EMDR-type technique

I know you have been experiencing flashbacks relating to that trauma, and this has been getting you down.

I want to show you a way to dispel/reduce and/or eliminate those flashbacks and free yourself from the associated anxieties.

Note: If your client didn't identify any negative self-beliefs during the information-gathering stage, disregard the following two sentences. PAUSE

Think for a moment about whatever negative self-beliefs you formed from that experience and rate them on a scale of 1 to 10.

Perhaps you felt as though you could have done more, or maybe you felt as though you had failed or let someone down.

If the client didn't form any negative beliefs, move onto the part of the script where they create a screen. PAUSE

Now I want you to choose a new, positive self-belief that better represents how you would like to feel and again, select a number from 1 to 10 that represents how true you believe this to be.

Nod your head when you've done this.

Wait for the signal. PAUSE

Now, I'd like you to pick a specific picture from a scene or a target event that best represents how you feel about your negative belief.

Let me know once you've done this.

Wait for a signal. PAUSE

Good, now picture that scene in your mind as you take some nice deep, comfortable breaths.

That's right, breathe in, hold for three and breathe out. Each time you exhale your body can relax, more and more.

And as you see the image in your mind, and as you breathe deeply, I want you to open and close your eyes several times, and as you do this, you can talk about the event or what you are seeing in your mind, if you wish.

Or if you prefer, you don't have to say anything at all. It is entirely your choice as to whether you do, or whether you don't, but whichever you decide, I want you to keep breathing steadily in and out, holding each one for the mental count of three before breathing out and opening and closing your eyes.

You can start this whenever you are ready.

Watch for client opening and closing their eyes, and when they have done this a few times, continue as follows: NOTE

Good, now I want you to blank that scene from your mind and focus on your positive self-belief.

Let me know when you've done this.

Wait for a signal. PAUSE

That's good. Now I want you to tell me or make a mental note in your head, using the scale of 1 to 10, how true your negative belief is to you now.

If the number hasn't reduced, repeat the exercise (several times if necessary). You can

then move onto another picture from the traumatic event.

Reducing painful memories

I'd like you to create a screen in your mind, and on to that screen, I would like you to project the most traumatic of those memories.

You might like to break down these memories into small chunks and rate each one of them on a scale of one to ten, depending on how much they bother you.

A rating of one would mean that it hardly bothers you at all, while ten would be the most traumatic.

When you come to view this screen in your mind, I want you to be aware that you are standing some distance away as though you were watching an event from afar and it was happening to someone else.

If the traumatic event **did** happen to someone else, omit the last 7 words.	NOTE

As you go through your memories of that event, I want you to know and to understand that you are completely safe and distanced from any negative emotions and at ***no time,*** will you feel as though you are back there.

I repeat, you are completely safe and watching this screen from a distance, and whatever you see, feel or hear, cannot - will not - affect you in the same way it did in the past.

You are also holding a remote control, so if at any time you need or want to stop watching the screen, all you need to do is press ***pause*** or ***stop***, and the images, sounds, emotions and memories will instantly disappear.

Okay, when you are ready, I want you to press ***go*** on your remote, and watch and listen as that event commences.

At this stage, keep a close eye on the subject, and if you notice any distress, instruct them to press pause or stop and take them to a “safe place”. NOTE

Let me know by nodding your head once you have reviewed this scene from beginning to end.

Wait for the signal. PAUSE

That’s good, you are doing really well. Now I want you to rewind the scene very quickly in your mind and go back to the beginning to when the screen was blank.

Now, as you look at the screen, I want you to notice how there are ropes that are attached to the screen and to you.

These ropes have been binding that unpleasant memory to you and soon, very soon, we are going to free you of any negative emotions associated with that painful event.

Okay, so I want you to press play or go again, but this time, when you watch what happened, notice how the colors are dimmer; the sound is muted, and the negative feelings are diminishing.

Nod your head when you have done this.

Wait for the signal. PAUSE

Good, and now I want you to look to the side of you and notice an implement there that will help you to cut through those ropes.

Do you see it? Good, pick it up and cut through the ropes.

And the moment you cut through the very last piece of thread, notice how the screen begins moving backwards, away from you.

It is moving further and further back. The sound is so quiet and muffled; the image is barely visible now, and the feelings are so minute you can hardly sense them.

And in a moment, the screen will totally disappear.

There, it is gone. The screen has completely gone, and so have the memories and any negative emotions associated with it.

You are free. You are free from the negative feelings and emotions that bothered you so much. Yes, you know that the event happened and you cannot change history, but you have freed yourself from the painful reminders and negative feelings and now it is time to move on.

Move on and up.

Bring back the white screen now. See it is totally clean.

And on this screen, I want you to place an image of yourself as a person who has healed.

You are no longer a victim of the past; you are a survivor, and as such, you have plenty of life to look forward to.

See yourself surrounded by people you love and who love you back.

See how you are surrounded by new opportunities. You might even move the images into the future and notice what you will be doing in two or three years' time.

You can make plans for the future, knowing that everything will work out for the best.

Now, notice this future you sitting on a horse. It is ***your*** horse, a beautiful, faithful creature, and you hold the reins.

You are stable and comfortable and able to direct your horse to wherever you wish to go.

You are fully able to harness your emotions and channel your energy into productive

activities and a happy and fulfilling life.

Your horse is ready to begin its journey. ***You*** are ready, and it is time to go.

I will be quiet for a few moments, and in the silence, allow your subconscious mind to identify all the resources you need for your new adventure in life.

A short pause and proceed to count up.	PAUSE

In a moment, I will count the numbers from one to five and at the count of five, you will be fully alert and refreshed.

One, two, three, coming slowly back; four, eyelids becoming lighter, perhaps even flickering, and five, eyes open, wide away, ready to begin your adventure in life.

Eyes open, wide awake, mind and body returning to full conscious awareness.

Please note: this session is intended for relaxation purposes only. It is not a medical or therapeutic device and is not intended to diagnose, treat, cure or prevent any medical condition or disease.